PHQ-9 — Depression Severity

adults & adolescents · over the last 2 weeks · OPD / ward

PHQ-9 0–27

OVER THE LAST 2 WEEKS, HOW OFTEN BOTHERED BY…

0	1	2	3
Not at all	Several days	More than half the days	Nearly every day

ITEMS (EACH 0–3)

Item	0–3
1. Little interest or pleasure in doing things	0–3
2. Feeling down, depressed or hopeless	0–3
3. Trouble falling/staying asleep, or sleeping too much	0–3
4. Feeling tired or having little energy	0–3
5. Poor appetite or overeating	0–3
6. Feeling bad about yourself — a failure, or let yourself or family down	0–3
7. Trouble concentrating (e.g. reading, TV)	0–3
8. Moving/speaking so slowly others notice — or fidgety/restless	0–3
9. Thoughts that you would be better off dead, or of hurting yourself	0–3
Total	**0–27**

FUNCTION (NOT SCORED)

▸ How difficult have these problems made it to work, take care of things at home or get along with others? Not / somewhat / very / extremely

SEVERITY

- **0–4** Minimal
- **5–9** Mild — watchful waiting, repeat
- **10–14** Moderate — treatment plan (counselling ± medication)
- **15–19** Moderately severe — active treatment
- **20–27** Severe — medication + psychotherapy; refer if poor response

ITEM 9

- **Item 9 ≥1** Any positive answer → suicide risk assessment today, regardless of total

SA GUIDELINES

- Depression = low mood and/or reduced capacity to enjoy life; often not recognised — may lead to suicide ✚
- Antenatal MCR 3-question screen: self-harm thoughts AND plans, or previous attempt → urgent mental health assessment ✚
- Diagnosis ≥10 has ~88% sensitivity & specificity for major depression

PHC STG & EML Primary Healthcare, 8th ed. 2024 (updated Sept 2026) — pp 16.15 · **MAT24** National Integrated Maternal & Perinatal Care Guidelines for SA, 5th ed. 2024 — pp 22 · **PHQ9** Kroenke K et al. PHQ-9. J Gen Intern Med 2001;16:606-13 (Pfizer, free to use)

✚ = SA STG / national guideline (pages listed above). Unmarked content: international source named above. ‡ = STG misprint or sources differ (see app). ANDH · phq9 · updated 2026-10-14